



Petra

The “Rose-red City,” capital of the Nabataean Kingdom, famous for the tombs and temples carved into its sandstone cliffs

The nomadic Nabataean people settled in the desert mountains of present-day southern Jordan more than 10,000 years ago, founding a settlement, Raqmu, that was to become a trading center for the region. Trade with the Greek and Roman empires brought prosperity, and the growing city became known as Petra, Greek for “stone.”

Carved into the rock

Petra’s location in steep-sided mountain gorges led the Nabataeans to develop a distinctive architecture, carving tombs and temples that mimicked the Greco-Roman Classical style but also included some characteristically Nabataean elements. The finest examples of this are the famous Al-Khazneh (“the Treasury,” although it is in fact a mausoleum) at the entrance to the city and the Monastery, Al-Deir (actually a hilltop temple). Also of note is the row of four Royal Tombs—the Tomb of Urns, Silk Tomb, Corinthian Tomb, and Palace Tomb—each featuring a different Classical genre.

The city also has a huge theater hewn from the rock and a small number of free-standing buildings, such as the Qasr-al-Bint, the main temple of the city. Several of the soft sandstone buildings have suffered from erosion, and even in the best preserved ones the details have lost clarity.

At the height of its prosperity in the **1st century CE**, Petra had an estimated **population of 20,000**

◀ ROCK-CUT TOMBS

The tombs cut into the walls of the gorge leading into Petra are comparatively simple in design, but the multicolored, striated sandstone creates spectacular interiors, which were originally also decorated with frescoes.

